

Regular Meeting
May 4, 2015
School Committee Meeting
Council Chambers

The Regular Meeting of the Medford School Committee was called to order by Vice Chairperson John Falco in the City Hall Council Chambers at 7:07 p.m. Those present were Ms. Cugno, Ms. DiBenedetto, Mr. Falco, Mr. Scarpelli, Mr. Skerry, Ms. Van der Kloot and Superintendent Belson. Mayor McGlynn was absent

On the motion of Mr. Skerry that the minutes of April 13, 2015 be approved:

Vote:

Yes: 6
No: 0
Absent: 1

On the motion of Mr. Skerry that the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved:

Voted: That the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 6 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Falco, Scarpelli, Skerry, Van der Kloot
Nay: 0
Absent: 1 McGlynn

On the motion of Mr. Skerry that the Payrolls be approved:

Voted: That the Payrolls be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 6 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Falco, Scarpelli, Skerry, Van der Kloot
Nay: 0
Absent: 1 McGlynn

Report on High School Accreditation

Superintendent Belson reported that we are pleased to report that the New England Association of Schools and Colleges (NEASC) acting on behalf of its Commission on secondary schools has awarded Medford High School/Medford Vocational Technical High School full re-accreditation for a ten year period. This is the best rating possible under the NEASC system. The high school accreditation process is a major undertaking. Congratulations and credit for the preparation of our self-study and evidentiary submission as well as the competence of our site visit belongs to the leadership of both the high school and vocational school, steering committee, faculty, staff and students. Among the many significant findings were the following the School Board, Superintendent and Principal are collaborative, reflective and constructive in achieving their school's 21st century learning expectations. The school is a safe and respectful environment that responds to the diversity of the school community. The school has made significant capital improvements and technology investments. There is strong

collaboration between the Principal of Medford High School and the Director of the Vocational School. Teachers who personalize instruction to help meet the needs of a majority of students. The use of formative and summative assessments in the classroom for the purpose of informing instruction. The teachers practice of giving timely feedback to students. The students who feel supported and cared for by their teachers. The personalized care and attention that is given to the various wellness needs of the school community. The active and effective site council and parent teacher organizations. The cultivation of many productive partnerships. These commendations are only a sampling of the findings by the visiting committee and the Commission. Naturally, there are recommendations for improvement as well. However, when taken in context, the overall picture of our high school and vocational school is excellent. After you have had time to digest this seventy-four page document we will schedule a Committee of the Whole to formally review the findings and the take appropriate next steps. Superintendent Belson introduced Headmaster Perella, Assistant Principal Nick Tucci and Steering Committee Chairperson Candace Margles. Dr. Perella said that it was a whole package of celebration the administration, teachers and students. We are very proud but everyone deserves recognition.

Discussion:

All members offered congratulations to Dr. Perella and the steering committee. Ms. Van der Kloot said that what struck her the most was the positive comments on the school culture. We should celebrate the diversity. Also she said to read that the students are cared for is what you want to hear as a school committee member. Ms. Cugno said that as a parent she feels so good knowing her children attend such a great school with a great atmosphere. Ms. DiBenedetto spoke to Dr. Perella saying you are doing such wonderful work. We received some recommendations but we will get them done. Mr. Scarpelli said we need to get the word out about MHS, it is a great place. Mr. Skerry said it is great to see the teachers come forth, all did a great job. Ms. Van der Kloot asked if the Superintendent could perhaps find a little money so that a celebration for teachers and students could be planned. Dr. Perella said he loves the idea of celebrating with the students. The students make us what we are. It is a full collaboration.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto the report was accepted and placed on file.

Yes: 6

No: 0

Absent: 1

Recommendation to Accept Gift to Medford High School from Silvio Cella Foundation
Superintendent Belson reported that the Medford High School football program has received the Silvio Cella Foundation Grant in the amount of \$3,000 which is given annually to two Massachusetts high school programs. Coach Cella made countless contributions to high school football and student athletes during his forty-nine year career as a coach and athletic director at Revere High School. Superintendent Belson introduced Coach Nascimento and Chris Murphy, President of the Football Association. Coach Nascimento thanked everyone and said that they plan to use the money for new

uniforms, equipment and camps for the players. Mr. Murphy said that the money will help bring the team to the next level.

Discussion:

Ms. Cugno said that she would like to commend Coach Nascimento on the academic side as well. Ms. DiBenedetto asked if he applied for this. He said that Athletic Director Maloney had applied for it. Ms. Van der Kloot said this is great that our students are recognized as good athletes.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry to accept the gift:

Yea: 6 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Falco, Scarpelli, Skerry, Van der Kloot

Nay: 0

Absent: 1 McGlynn

Recommendation to Approve Extended Year, Day and Evening Programs at Medford Vocational Technical High School

Superintendent Belson introduced Director Heidi Riccio to present the report. Ms. Riccio began by explaining the evening programs. This will provide opportunities for our recent graduates who have chosen to continue in their respective technical area as well as increase technical offerings for the greater community of Medford to explore evening school options. The summer program will consist of a three-week program for incoming 8th graders at a nominal cost to provide CTE opportunities. This year programs and space will be limited. It is intended that this will occur each summer as a promotional tool for the vocational high school by opening the doors to our middle school students.

Discussion:

Mr. Scarpelli asked if the tuition collected will cover the cost of running the programs. Ms. Riccio said that the intent is to be self sustaining but they may have a loss in the first three years. Ms. Cugno said that the intent should not be to make money but to show students the opportunities at the vocational school. Ms. DiBenedetto asked if the evening school is for graduates that need continuing hours? Ms. Riccio answered that it is for recent grads and existing members of the workforce. Ms. Van der Kloot asked if sixty students is the max for the summer and will it be taught by existing staff. Ms. Riccio said that this year it will be capped at sixty students. They will post the positions as they do all summer school opportunities. Ms. Van der Kloot asked why Gould pulled out? Ms. Riccio said they were running the program at three locations and are streamlining to one. Ms. DiBenedetto said that she would like to see the equipment maintained with any profit received.

On the motion of Mr. Scarpelli to approve the extended year, day and evening programs at Medford Vocational Technical High School.

Yes: 6

No: 0

Absent: 1

Report on Robotics Project at Medford Vocational Technical High School

Ms. Riccio introduced electrical teacher Rich Cormio and student Hunter Raymond. Ms. Riccio said that Hunter Raymond was recently included in the April edition of Techdirections magazine. Hunter is a senior in the electrical program who began taking an elective coding class with volunteer software engineers. As a result, he began to seek better ways to communicate to Rich Cormio, an instructor in the electrical program who was on a medical leave for a rare form of cancer. Hunter, working with the software engineers and our new engineering instructor learned how to code and develop a software application that can control an android tablet remotely from MVTHS to Mr. Cormio's computer. He then built a device with the assistance of the metal fabrication program that moves and is able to navigate through rows of desks so that Mr. Cormio could teach his electrical students from home. Since then, Hunter has competed at Skills USA state competition, was on Boston.com and will be visiting iRobot in May. Hunter will also be seen soon on the Channel 7 news. Ms. Riccio introduced Hunter who explained how this all came about and the process of building the robot. He thanked all the shops at MVTHS for the help with anything he needed. Mr. Cormio said it was an incredible experience. He said when he mentioned this idea to Superintendent Belson his reply was "go home and get better." He said by the time they perfected everything he was back to school. Mr. Cormio thanked everyone for all the support and prayers.

Discussion:

All members of the committee congratulated Hunter and welcomed Mr. Cormio back. Ms. Van der Kloot said this is a great project with such potential. Mr. Scarpelli said that Hunter is an unbelievable role model and this is just another example of the great things happening in Medford. Ms. Cugno said how extremely proud she is and that these are the stories the community needs to hear. We need to promote these students. Ms. DiBenedetto commented on the incredible bond that formed between this student and his teacher. It is the dream of every teacher to be able to motivate, drive and develop this type of relationship. Mr. Skerry said that Hunter took the bull by the horns and did something no one else has ever done. Job well done.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot the report was accepted and placed on file.

Yes: 6

No: 0

Absent: 1

Recommendation to Approve School Lunch Price Increase for SY 2015-2016

Director of Administration and Finance Pat Velie presented the report. Ms. Velie said that the Medford Public Schools (MPS) breakfast and lunch program serves a large portion of the school population and is currently at a financial breakeven point. However, the Food Service Program must ask at this time that a price increase be approved for both the breakfast and lunch services due to Federal regulations and inherent cost increases. The requested price increases are federally and financially necessary. At the Federal level the price increase assists the district in meeting regulations requiring school food authorities participating in the National School Lunch Program to ensure sufficient funds are provided to the nonprofit school food service

account for meals served to students not eligible for free or reduced priced meals. The food service program is breaking even with the current revenue stream and the current expenses. Food costs have been increasing and reducing any reserves for maintenance and replacement of aging equipment. Additional increased costs can be expected due to undetermined collective bargaining. The current cost of breakfast is \$1.00 with an increase of \$0.50 bringing the new price to \$1.50. The request for the lunch increase is \$0.25 per lunch. The current price of lunch is \$2.50 at the elementary and \$2.85 at the middle and high schools resulting in the new price of \$2.75 and \$3.10. The requested price increase should align the food service program with the USDA regulations for the next three years barring any extreme food or labor cost increases.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot said that she understands the federal government piece but is shocked by the increase to the breakfast. She said that many families are just squeaking by and do not qualify for free/reduced so this would be a lot of money for them. Ms. Velie said that they conducted a survey of surrounding communities to see what they charge for breakfast and lunch. Mr. Skerry requested a copy of the survey results. Mr. Scarpelli would like the item tabled. He would like to look at the food service budget before making any decision.

On the motion of Mr. Scarpelli the report was tabled.

Yes: 6

No: 0

Absent: 1

Mr. Scarpelli requested that Juile Bradley be present to discuss the increase in cost. Ms. DiBenedetto asked how much money is taken in and would like a budget update and also equipment update. Mr. Skerry would like a report on what machines need to be replaced or are not working.

Recommendation to Reject School Choice Program for SY 2015-2016

Superintendent Belson stated that under current school law, a school district is assumed to be accepting school choice students for SY 2015-2016, unless the School Committee votes to the contrary. Consequently, I must report an official vote of the Medford School Committee to the Department of Education in June 2015. Otherwise, the Medford School Committee will be obligated to participate in the School Choice Program for the upcoming school year. The School Choice program I am referring to is the external version, not the intradistrict program of choice. After careful consideration, it is my recommendation that the Medford School Committee vote not to participate in the School Choice Program for SY 2015-2016. This has been our position since the beginning of the program. If we are to participate, we would have to accept students from other communities in the Commonwealth for baseline tuition, which could be well below the actual cost of the services that may occur. Such acceptances would be on a seat-available basis and could also affect enrollments selectively throughout the district, and as a result, trigger costs which would add to our budgetary burden. Furthermore, the Medford School Committee has continuously expressed a desire to emphasize servicing Medford students,

and to concentrate our efforts in that direction. Lastly, by rejecting this provision, we do not compromise our ability to work with students in our special education programs or our Chapter 74 vocational programs, which are beneficial to our overall program and financial position. For all of the above reasons, I am asking the School Committee to take a vote to reject School Choice for the SY 2015-2016, so that I may notify the Department of Education before the deadline.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry to reject school choice for SY 2015 -2016

Yea: 6 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Falco, Scarpelli, Skerry, Van der Kloot

Nay: 0

Absent: 1 McGlynn

Pre Budget Report - Mathematics

Deputy Superintendent Beverly Nelson reported that tonight we will continue our pre budget presentations. We will begin tonight with Carolyn Joy, Director of Mathematics. Ms. Joy stated that the mathematics program supports the teaching and learning of mathematics in grades kindergarten through twelve in the Medford Public Schools. Support includes supervision and evaluation of instruction across grade levels, analysis of student data and review of the effectiveness of program materials. The curriculum document is aligned to the 2011 Massachusetts Mathematics Curriculum Framework that is based on the Common Core State Standards. She said that the math curriculum is standards-based with a shared emphasis on math practice and content. Math courses for special populations are aligned to the district's curriculum. Ms. Joy reported on the department's highlights for the year, staffing needs and funding requests for next year.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot asked Ms. Joy what a document camera is? Ms. Joy answered that it is a device that sits on the desk that you put a paper under and it can project the students work. Ms. Van der Kloot asked what the cost is? Ms. Joy answered approximately \$300. Mr. Falco asked if all teachers have been trained in Envision? Ms. Joy answered yes.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry the report was accepted and placed on file.

Yes: 6

No: 0

Absent: 1

Pre Budget Health and Physical Education

Rachel Perry presented the report. Ms. Perry said that the goal of the physical education and health department is to enhance the well-being of the school community by creating a culture that integrates and balances the six dimensions of wellness: social, physical, intellectual, occupational, emotional and spiritual. The department strives to encourage an active, healthy lifestyle, healthy decision-making and a life-long commitment to wellness. Ms. Perry discussed the department's highlights for the year, staffing needs and funding requests for next year.

Discussion:

Mr. Scarpelli asked what the average number of students in health classes is? Ms. Perry said that the max number is 30. Mr. Scarpelli asked who evaluates the teachers. Ms. Perry replied that administration does the evaluations. Mr. Scarpelli questioned whether the \$5,000 is enough for maintenance of the equipment. Ms. Perry answered yes. Ms. DiBenedetto requested a meeting on social/emotional learning because every department has mention of it in their presentation. Ms. Nelson said that they were told to include it in there budgets so that we can address this issue. Ms. Cugno questioned whether the 30 students are over contract. Ms. Nelson replied that core content is 24 students. Ms. Cugno asked if anyone has explained the Michigan Model to parents? Ms. Perry said that it is discussed at the 8th grade night but she is willing to post information on the website. Mr. Skerry asked the Superintendent to work with Ms. Perry to have professional development in adaptive physical education in place for September.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry the report was accepted and placed on file.

Yes: 6
No: 0
Absent: 1

Pre Budget – English Language Learners

ELL Coordinator Leslie Trotta presented the report. She said that the ELL department offers a wide range of programs that services LEP students in grades k-12. This year there are approximately 365 students with 29 languages. At the elementary level, we have a Newcomers Program at the Roberts Elementary School. The middle school program is housed at the McGlynn Middle School where classes are offered in math, social studies, science and ELL Language Arts. At Medford High School we offer ELL classes in math, social studies, science and ELL Language Arts that are appropriate for Newcomers, and classes that mirror the mainstream curriculum for ELL students with a greater command of the English language. Support classes are offered to LEP and FLEP students in math, science, social studies, ELL Language Arts and assessments. Ms. Trotta discussed the department's highlights for the year and staffing needs and funding requests for next year. She announced that Theresa Castignetti was named Teacher of the Year by MATSOL.

Discussion:

Members congratulated Theresa Castignetti and would like to invite her to an upcoming meeting. Mr. Scarpelli asked if there were any class size issues. Ms. Trotta said that the grade 4/5 at the Roberts Newcomers could be a potential problem but it is hard to predict. Ms. DiBenedetto asked what the large increase in software is for? Ms. Trotta answered that it is for the elementary program Brainpop.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry the report was accepted and placed on file.

Yes: 6
No: 0
Absent: 1

Report on Summer Programs

Dr. Bernadette Ricciardelli presented the report. Dr. Ricciardelli said that over the past several weeks administrators have been meeting to plan this year's summer programs. She highlighted each program. The programs include regular summer school, English Language Learners summer program, summer fun program, middle school computer science camp, Medford Vocational Technical High School's Career and Technical Education exploration program, High School 101 and various special education programs. She stated that the summer fun camp will be held at Medford High School this year.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot asked how many students will be able to attend the computer science camp. Dr. Ricciardelli said around 15 but it is designed to take students in computer classes already. Ms. DiBenedetto asked if moving the summer camp to the high school will affect it in any way. Dr. Ricciardelli said that the main reason for moving it was to be able to utilize the pool. They will evaluate at the end of the summer. Mr. Scarpelli commented that he has spoken to Anthony Petrelis who is the director of the fun camp and he said that being at Medford High School will offer a safer area with the indoor pool, the large gymnasium and the outdoor fields. This is all positive. Mr. Falco said that this will give the Columbus School time to get a thorough cleaning. Ms. Cugno commented that during inclement weather the children will have a large gym and still be able to swim. Ms. DiBenedetto said the Columbus deserves a break. Mr. Falco asked for a follow-up report at the end of the summer.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot the report was accepted and placed on file.

Yes: 6

No: 0

Absent: 1

New Business:

School Committee Resolutions

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Robert Delfino. Mr. Delfino was a former city assessor.

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Gerald Eisenhower. Mr. Eisenhower was the father of Sped Supervisor Joan Bowen.

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Ann DiBenedetto. Miss DiBenedetto was the sister in law of School Committee Member Erin DiBenedetto.

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere

condolences to the family of John “Jack” Regan. Mr. Regan was a former teacher, coach and athletic director. He was the father of teacher Joan Cavalier.

A moment of silence was held.

Superintendent Belson went over a list of possible dates for meetings.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry that meeting be adjourned at 10:00 p.m.

Respectfully submitted:

Robert E. Skerry Jr
Secretary